

Understanding Vishing and Smishing in Nigerian Slums Through Social Science Principles

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Vishing and smishing scams in Nigerian slums are largely driven by peer influence, economic conditions, and low digital awareness, making cybersecurity education essential to reduce victimization.

This essay argues that vishing and smishing scams in Nigerian slums are shaped by a combination of social, economic, and environmental factors, where peer influence, economic inequality, and low digital literacy contribute to both the normalization of cybercrime among perpetrators and the heightened vulnerability of victims, as explained through key social science principles such as social interaction, cause and effect, multiple perspectives, and Routine Activity Theory. Going forward, I will explore the seven principles of social science, including human behavior, social interaction, cause and effect, inequality, patterns, multiple perspectives, and ethics.

First, the article incorporates several social science principles by viewing how human behavior is determined by social, economic, and environmental factors. Scam and phishing attacks are dangerous due to the deliberate manipulation of human behavior. According to the article, “scammers, especially in the case of social engineering, was the deliberate manipulation of emotions” (Adeyemo et al., 2026, p. 31). For instance, scammers may target elderly individuals by using emotional manipulation or artificial intelligence to lead victims to believe that a family member is in danger; therefore, money must be transferred to resolve the situation.

Second, the principle of social interaction explains how individuals influence one another’s behavior, including involvement in crime. The study illustrates this through the strong peer influence present in communities like Ajegunle, where cybercriminals are often admired rather than condemned. In these environments, offenders are perceived as intelligent and hardworking, and illegal activities such as scamming are normalized. As one participant

explained, “When I dress well and use a good phone, they watch me. Sometimes, boys even ask me to show them small tricks” (Adeyemo et al., 2026, p. 34). This demonstrates how social approval and observation encourage others to adopt similar behaviors. As a result, crime becomes reinforced through everyday interactions, increasing the likelihood of continued offending and the expansion of cybercrime within the community.

Third, the principle of cause and effect is also demonstrated throughout the article, as it explains how specific social, economic, and environmental conditions lead to predictable behavioral outcomes. The study shows that cybercrime is not random but is shaped by underlying causes such as poverty, unemployment, weak institutional protection, and low digital literacy. These conditions directly contribute to increased vulnerability among victims while also motivating offenders to engage in cyber fraud as a means of survival.

Fourth, economic inequality is prevalent within the article, as both groups come from low-income slum environments. However, perpetrators often turn this limitation into a means of survival by using cyber fraud as a source of income. According to the article, “Offenders, usually peers or mentors in close-knit networks, employ voice calls (vishing) and fraudulent SMS (smishing) to target residents whose poverty and low digital literacy make them vulnerable” (Adeyemo et al., 2026, p. 28). Victims, on the other hand, are typically financially vulnerable individuals who cannot easily absorb financial losses or recover after being scammed. Although both groups experience economic disadvantages, perpetrators actively exploit the economic fragility of others for personal gain.

This situation can also be explained using Routine Activity Theory. The perpetrators represent motivated offenders, the victims serve as suitable targets due to their vulnerability, and the absence of capable guardianship is reflected in weak cybersecurity awareness, limited

institutional protection, and low reporting of cybercrime. Together, these conditions create an environment in which cybercrime can occur and persist.

Fifth, the principle of patterns is evident in the article, as cybercrime behavior shows repeated and predictable methods. The research shows that many victims share similar vulnerabilities, such as economic hardship, low cybersecurity awareness, and lack of digital literacy (p. 37). Although the study focuses on vishing and smishing attacks in Nigeria, the issue is global, as victims worldwide are regularly targeted through similar scam techniques.

Sixth, the principle of multiple perspectives is conveyed in this article through the inclusion of both perpetrators and victims who share their experiences with social engineering attacks. The study demonstrates that cybercrime is interpreted differently depending on an individual's role. For example, perpetrators may view scamming as a source of income or a skill, while victims experience it as financial and emotional harm.

Lastly, the principle of ethics and consideration is evident in the study. It is important to acknowledge that even among cybercriminals, moral boundaries sometimes exist. Although some scammers exploit victims for financial gain, others show hesitation when targeting people they know. As one participant explained, "It is difficult to look at them in the face after doing that, especially when they are older and those who have helped me before" (Adeyemo et al., 2026, p. 32). This demonstrates that even offenders may apply personal ethical limits based on relationships and social ties.

In conclusion, vishing and smishing scams in Nigerian slums are not simply acts of individual wrongdoing, but are shaped by complex social, economic, and environmental forces that influence both perpetrators and victims. The study demonstrates how peer influence, economic hardship, weak institutional protection, and low digital literacy contribute to the

normalization of cybercrime and increased vulnerability within these communities. By applying social science principles, it becomes clear that cybercrime is caused by larger social systems rather than one individual actions alone. Because of this, addressing these crimes requires not only stronger enforcement but also better cybersecurity education, increased community awareness, and stronger institutional support systems.

Work Cited

Adeyemo, L. J., Olabulo, T. Y., & Peter, I. G. (2026). Vishing and smishing perpetrators and their victims in Nigerian slums. *International Journal of Cybersecurity Intelligence & Cybercrime*, 9(1), 23–43. <https://doi.org/10.52306/2578-3289.120>